modesty which, while showing a rather orthodox Padshah, tells us that this was a common enough occurrence for it to have been commented upon. These incidents, in addition to Badauni's frequent, gloating commentary and indeed Badauni's own lasting infatuation with a youth, showed the limits of the Padshah's attempts to regulate and control his officers' behaviour and inculcate a reliable standard of male virtue.

Badauni's own conflicted views on women reflected a common social malaise regarding the kinds of behaviour that were acceptable in women. In his view, a 'pious and veiled woman' was always to be lauded and he proposed a punishment of eighty lashes for anyone who unjustly accused such a woman of adultery, for women, he argued, were less prone to such lust than men. Badauni's solution to protect women from the unsolicited passions of men was to ensure they were veiled, quiet, and invisible. And, he argued paradoxically, it was women who were the fatal distraction for men and they were the 'robbers whom we encounter on our road to God'. Even more violently critical of women was Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi who said that 'their nature is so wicked that in every adultery the woman must be regarded as the main culprit, since the act would not, for example, be possible without her consent'.

In this milieu Akbar's views were decidedly more nuanced and if he sought to regulate people's sexuality within the confines of heterosexual unions, it was nonetheless with a greater degree of awareness of the pressures that vulnerable women were subjected to and a more robust acceptance of men's share of responsibility in their unions.

As he grew older, Akbar's thoughts on his own marriages underwent a great change because he now often mentioned to Abu'l Fazl that 'had I formerly possessed the knowledge which I now have, I would never have chosen a wife for myself, for upon old women I look as mothers, on women of my age as sisters, and on girls as daughters'. As for young women, there were many instances in which he showed a protective and solicitous concern for their well-being:

> He is grave and very gentle and is always cautious with maidens and is in no way lost in lust for them. He does not pay attention only to their appearances and has in several instances also prevented lustful men from being overly desirous of them.